

the remaining fruits, producing the largest possible. Thin them to leave about 4–6 in (10–15 cm) between fruits (see image, left).

Pear trees are more susceptible to frost damage than apple trees because they produce their blossom earlier in the season—so, if possible, protect trees with horticultural fleece.

HARVESTING

It is crucial to time the harvesting of your pears carefully; if you harvest early or midseason pears too early and leave them indoors for too long, or harvest them too late, they may become grainy and unpalatable, or rot prematurely. Test fruits to check that they are sweet, and then pick them while they are still slightly underripe. When late-season pears pull easily away from the tree they can be brought inside and stored.

STORING

Pears store for varying times—some varieties will keep until the following spring, so see individual cultivar entries for more specific information. Pears need to be kept in a cool, dark place. Ensure that fruits are not touching each other, and check regularly for signs of rot.

PESTS AND DISEASES

Comparisons are often made between apples and pears, and when it comes to fighting off pests and diseases pears are the clear winners. Although they are not completely invincible, they face far fewer problems.

If aphids are spotted or pear leaf midge suspected, use a plant oil wash in winter and, if necessary, spray trees with a pyrethroid insecticide after blossom has dropped. Place grease bands around the trunks to keep winter moth caterpillars from climbing up and laying eggs.

Trees may be vulnerable to diseases such as scab, brown rot, and fire blight—prune diseased plant parts and pick off damaged fruits. Destroy rather than compost infected material. Using sterilized tools when pruning will help reduce the risk and spread of disease.



Wasps (left) will target existing holes in fruits to feast on the sweet flesh. Pear leaf midge (right) cause leaves to roll and turn to red then black in color.